



Cambridge International AS & A Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE

9093/42

Paper 4 Language Topics

May/June 2026

MARK SCHEME

Maximum Mark: 50

Published

This mark scheme contains the instructions and marking guidance that our examiners used to mark candidate responses for this component.

Before they start marking, examiners complete a standardisation process. They review a range of candidate responses and discuss the mark scheme in detail to agree which answers can and cannot be accepted. Examiners award marks where it is clear that candidate responses have met the requirements of the mark scheme. These requirements may vary between different components or different versions of the same component, depending on the exact requirements of the question and the candidate responses seen during the standardisation process.

Sometimes, our mark schemes may allow marks to be awarded to responses which contain elements that are factually incorrect or for content not covered by the syllabus. We do this in response to the demands of a specific question to support candidates and make sure that our assessments are fair. However, these allowances should not be used as a guide for teaching and learning.

We cannot discuss the mark scheme with schools, and we recommend that schools read the mark scheme together with the assessment material and the Principal Examiner Report for Teachers.

This document consists of **9** printed pages.

General marking principles

All examiners must apply these marking principles when marking candidate responses.

1	Examiners must award marks for each response in line with: - the specific content defined in the mark scheme - the specific skills defined in the mark scheme or in the level descriptions - the standard of response required as exemplified by the standardisation scripts.
2	Examiners must award whole marks (not half marks, or other fractions).
3	Examiners must award marks positively . This means that: - marks are not deducted for errors or omissions - marks are awarded for correct/valid answers as defined in the mark scheme and also for other valid answers which go beyond the scope of the syllabus and mark scheme referring to your team leader as appropriate - the quality of spelling, punctuation and grammar are judged only when the mark scheme indicates that these features are specifically assessed in the question. However, the meaning of all responses must be unambiguous.
4	Examiners must consistently apply the requirements of the mark scheme and any rules for what to do when candidates have not followed instructions correctly.
5	Examiners must use the full range of marks defined in the mark scheme, unless limited by the quality of the candidate responses seen.
6	Examiners must award marks according to the mark scheme and must not award marks with grade thresholds or grade descriptions in mind.

English & Media-Specific Marking Principles**(To be read in conjunction with the General Marking Principles (and requiring further guidance on how to place marks within levels))****Components using level descriptions:**

- We use level descriptions as a guide to broad understanding of the qualities normally expected of, or typical of, work in a level.
- Level descriptions are a means of general guidance and should not be interpreted as hurdle statements.
- Where indicative content notes are supplied for a question, these are *not* a prescription of required content and must not be treated as such. Alternative correct points and unexpected answers in candidates' scripts must be given marks that fairly reflect the knowledge and skills demonstrated.
- While we may have legitimate expectations as to the ground most answers may occupy, we must at all times be prepared to meet candidates on their chosen ground, provided it is relevant ground (e.g. clearly related to and derived from a relevant passage/text and meeting the mark scheme requirements for the question).

Annotations guidance for centres

Examiners use a system of annotations as a shorthand for communicating their marking decisions to one another. Examiners are trained during the standardisation process on how and when to use annotations. The purpose of annotations is to inform the standardisation and monitoring processes and guide the supervising examiners when they are checking the work of examiners within their team. The meaning of annotations and how they are used is specific to each component and is understood by all examiners who mark the component.

We publish annotations in our mark schemes to help centres understand the annotations they may see on copies of scripts. Note that there may not be a direct correlation between the number of annotations on a script and the mark awarded. Similarly, the use of an annotation may not be an indication of the quality of the response.

The annotations listed below were available to examiners marking this component in this series.

Annotations

Annotation	Meaning
	Assessment Objective 1
	Assessment Objective 2
	Assessment Objective 4
	Repetition
	Omission
	Requires clarity
	Seen
Highlighter	Inaccurate
	Not relevant

English Language specific marking instructions:**AO1 Read and demonstrate understanding of a wide variety of texts. (Understanding)**

- Marks should be awarded for the accuracy of the candidate's understanding of the text and its features, **not** for any analysis of them which is recognised under AO3.
- Where comparison is required, marks should be awarded for the candidate's recognition of similarities and differences between the texts and their features, **not** for any consequent analysis.
- When awarding a 'best-fit' mark within a Level for each AO, consider each bullet point equally.

AO2 Write effectively, creatively, accurately and appropriately, for a range of audiences and purposes. (Writing)

- Marks should be awarded equally on the basis of the level of the candidate's written expression (range of features used and accuracy) and the development of their writing (its organisation and relevance to task and audience).
- When awarding a 'best-fit' mark within a Level for each AO, consider each bullet point equally.

AO4: Demonstrate understanding of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and approaches. (Conceptualisation)

- Marks should be awarded equally on the basis of the level of the candidate's understanding of the relevant issues, concepts, methods and approaches represented both in the text(s) and in their wider studies.
- When awarding a 'best-fit' mark within a Level for each AO, consider each bullet point equally.

Marking criteria for Section A Question 1 and Section B Question 2**Table A**

Level	AO1: Read and demonstrate understanding of a wide variety of texts. 10 marks	AO2: Write effectively, creatively, accurately and appropriately, for a range of audiences and purposes. 5 marks	AO4: Demonstrate understanding of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and approaches. 10 marks
5	- Sophisticated understanding of text (meaning/context/ audience) - Insightful reference to specific points 9–10 marks	- Sophisticated expression, with a high level of accuracy - Content is fully relevant; ideas are developed throughout in a sophisticated manner 5 marks	- Sophisticated understanding of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and approaches represented in the text - Insightful reference to wider study of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and approaches 9–10 marks
4	- Detailed understanding of text (meaning/context/ audience) - Effective reference to specific points 7–8 marks	- Effective expression, with a few minor errors which do not impede communication - Content is relevant; ideas are developed in an effective manner 4 marks	- Detailed understanding of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and approaches represented in the text - Effective reference to wider study of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and approaches 7–8 marks
3	- Clear understanding of text (meaning/context/ audience) - Clear reference to specific points 5–6 marks	- Clear expression, with occasional errors which do not impede communication - Content is relevant; ideas are developed clearly 3 marks	- Clear understanding of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and approaches represented in the text - Clear reference to wider study of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and approaches 5–6 marks

Level	AO1: Read and demonstrate understanding of a wide variety of texts. 10 marks	AO2: Write effectively, creatively, accurately and appropriately, for a range of audiences and purposes. 5 marks	AO4: Demonstrate understanding of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and approaches. 10 marks
2	- Limited understanding of text (meaning/context/ audience) - Limited reference to specific points 3–4 marks	- Expression is clear but may not flow easily, with frequent errors which generally do not impede communication - Content is mostly relevant; ideas are developed in a limited manner 2 marks	- Limited understanding of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and/or approaches represented in the text - Some limited reference to wider study of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and/or approaches 3–4 marks
1	- Basic understanding of text (meaning/context/ audience) - Minimal reference to specific points 1–2 marks	- Basic expression, with frequent errors which impede communication - Content may lack relevance in parts; minimal development of ideas 1 mark	- Minimal understanding of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and/or approaches represented in the text - Minimal reference to wider study of linguistic issues, concepts, methods and/or approaches 1–2 marks
0	No creditable content 0 marks	No creditable content 0 marks	No creditable content 0 marks

PUBLISHED

Question	Answer	Marks
1	Read the following text, which is the opening of an article published in 2023 on the website of the British weekly newspaper <i>The Economist</i>. Discuss what you feel are the most important issues raised in the text relating to the causes and effects of the expansion of English around the world. You should refer to specific details from the text as well as to ideas and examples from your wider study of English in the world. Mark according to the levels of response marking criteria in Table A. Additional guidance: The comments below are illustrative and are not intended to be exhaustive. Candidates may make other valid comments that should be credited. Responses might discuss the following: • how and why some European universities are <i>offering courses taught mostly – even entirely – in English</i> • the concept of <i>domain loss</i> as speakers use their first language in fewer academic contexts • the concern that languages may <i>eventually lack the vocabulary needed for cutting-edge topics</i> • the hegemony of English in the academic world, <i>leaving the impression that Dutch is somehow unworthy</i> • economic issues, such as students being <i>given cash grants for living expenses</i> and then <i>they may leave rather than staying and contributing to the economy</i> • how <i>global rankings of universities ... look at the number of international students and teachers as part of their assessment</i> and the issues which arise from that • other examples of the <i>backlash against English</i> and desire to promote national languages	25

PUBLISHED

Question	Answer	Marks
2	Read the following text, which is the opening to an article from the <i>Psychology Today</i> website. It was published in 2024. Discuss what you feel are the most important issues raised in the text relating to the ways in which language can shape and reflect how individuals think about themselves and about each other. You should refer to specific details from the text as well as to ideas and examples from your wider study of Language and the self. Mark according to the levels of response marking criteria in Table A. Additional guidance: The comments below are illustrative and are not intended to be exhaustive. Candidates may make other valid comments that should be credited. Responses might discuss the following: • how language choices can contribute to <i>gender inequality and the devaluing of women</i> • the concept of <i>gendered language</i> • the correlational link between <i>gendered language</i> and <i>gender inequality</i> • how and why <i>gendered language affects our psychology</i> • why <i>gendered diminutives</i> are being <i>replaced by gender-neutral terms</i> • how <i>these kinds of changes may help dismantle many of the deeply ingrained systems of biases</i> • how <i>pronoun usage</i> can affect how individuals are perceived and identify themselves • changes that could be made to language to rectify the situation	25